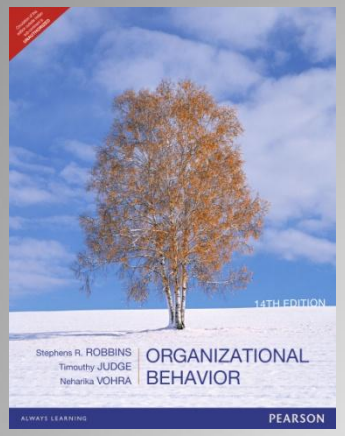

Chapter 11

Robbins, Judge, and Vohra

Organizational Behavior

14th Edition

Communication

Kelli J. Schutte
William Jewell College

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Chapter Learning Objectives

- **After studying this chapter, you should be able to:**
  - Identify the main functions of communication.
  - Describe the communication process and distinguish between formal and informal communication.
  - Contrast downward, upward, and lateral communication with examples.
  - Contrast oral, written, and nonverbal communication.
  - Contrast formal communication networks and the grapevine.
  - Analyze the advantages and challenges of electronic communication.
  - Show how channel richness underlies the choice of communication channel.
  - Identify common barriers to effective communication.
  - Show how to overcome the potential problems in cross-cultural communication.

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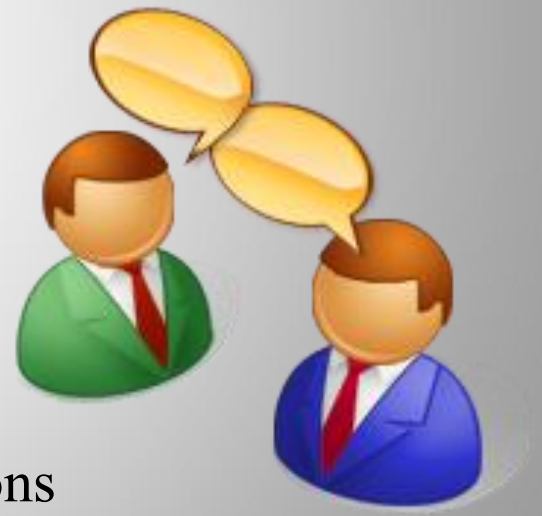
Functions of Communication

Communication

- The transference and understanding of meaning –
- Thought would be transmitted so the receiver understood the same mental picture the sender intended

➢ Communication Functions

- Control member behavior
- Foster motivation for what is to be done
- Provide a release for emotional expression
- Provide information needed to make decisions



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Control Member Behaviour

- Organizations have authority hierarchies and formal guidelines employees are required to follow. When employees follow their job descriptions or comply with company policies, communication performs a management function

- When workgroups tease or harass a member who produces too much (and makes the rest of the members look bad), they are informally communicating, and managing, the member's behavior.

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Motivation

- Communication creates feedback by clarifying to employees what they must do, how well they are doing it, and how they can improve their performance.

- Formation of goals, feedback on progress, and reward for desired behavior all require communication and stimulate motivation

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Emotional Expression

- The workgroup is a primary source of social interaction for many employees.

- Communication within the group is a fundamental mechanism by which members show satisfaction and frustration. Communication, therefore, provides for the *emotional sharing* of feelings and fulfillment of social needs.

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Make Decisions

- *information exchange* to facilitate decision making.

- Communication provides the information individuals and groups need to make decisions by transmitting the data needed to identify and evaluate choices.

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The Communication Process

- **Communication Process**
  - The steps between a source and a receiver that result in the transference and understanding of meaning

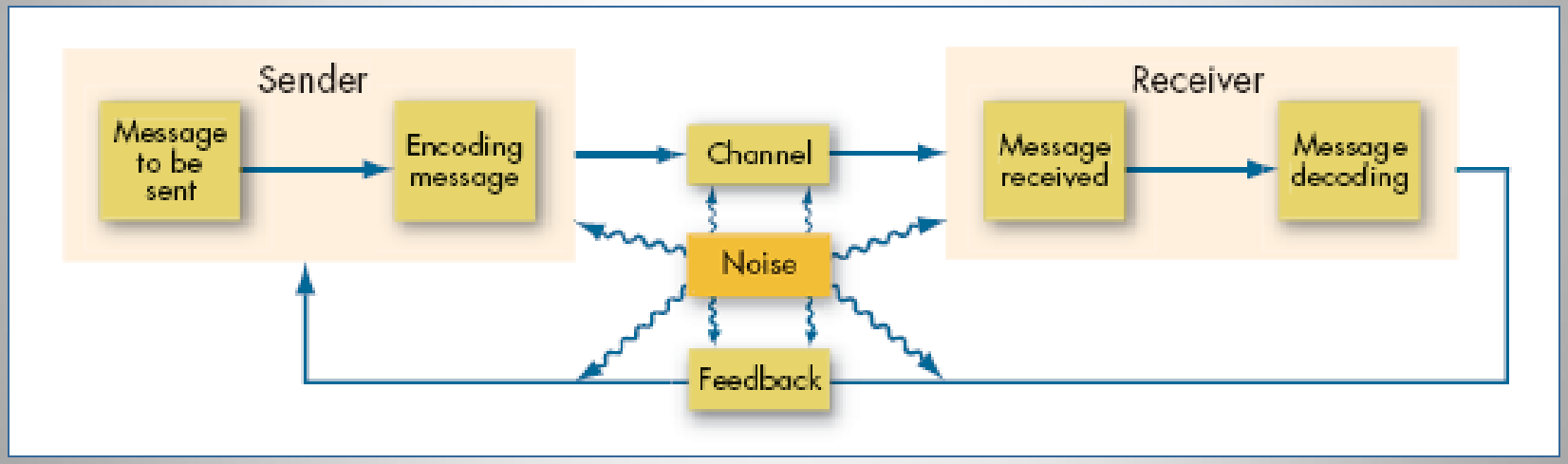

EXHIBIT 11-1

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Key Parts of Communication Process

- **The Sender** – *initiates message*
- **Encoding** – *translating thought to message*
- **The Message** – *what is communicated*
- **The Channel** – *the medium the message travels through*
- **Decoding** – *the receiver's action in making sense of the message*
- **The Receiver** – *person who gets the message*
- **Noise** – *things that interfere with the message*
- **Feedback** – *a return message regarding the initial communication*

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Communication Channels

Channel

- The medium selected by the sender through which the message travels to the receiver

➢ **Types of Channels**

- Formal Channels
  - Are established by the organization and transmit messages that are related to the professional activities of members
- Informal Channels
  - Used to transmit personal or social messages in the organization. These informal channels are spontaneous and emerge as a response to individual choices

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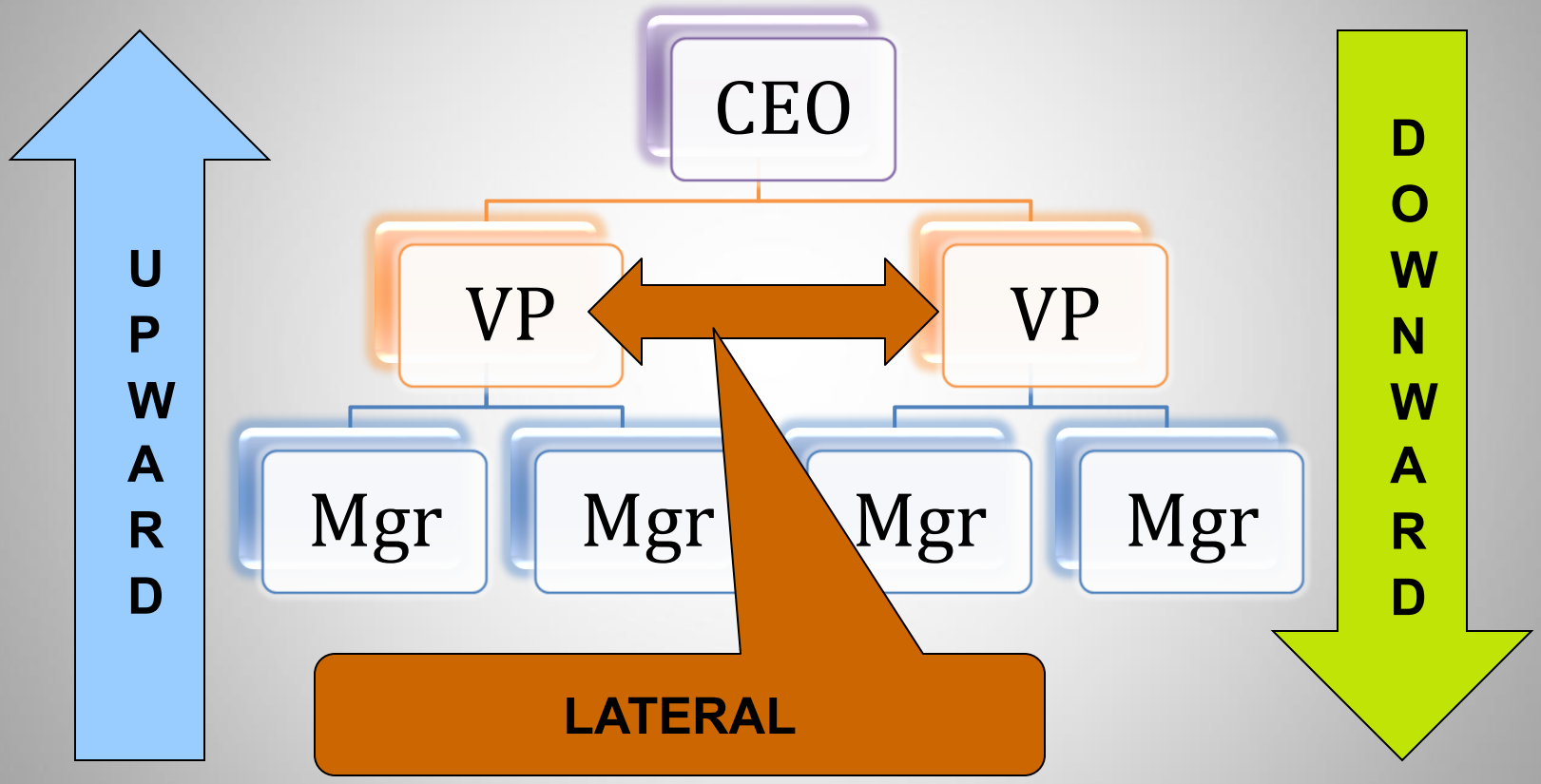
Direction of Communication



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Downward

- Communication that flows from one level of a group or organization to a lower level is *downward communication*.

- Group leaders and managers use it to assign goals, provide job instructions, explain policies and procedures, point out problems that need attention, and offer feedback

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Upward

- *Upward communication* flows to a higher level in the group or organization. It's used to provide feedback to higher-ups, inform them of progress toward goals, and relay current problems. Upward communication keeps managers aware of how employees feel about their jobs, coworkers, and the organization in general.

- Managers also rely on upward communication for ideas on how conditions can be improved.

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Lateral

- When communication occurs between members of the same workgroup, members at the same level in separate workgroups, or any other horizontally equivalent workers, we describe it as *lateral communication*

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Interpersonal Communication

- **Oral Communication**
  - Advantages: Speed and feedback
  - Disadvantage: Distortion of the message
- **Written Communication**
  - Advantages: Tangible and verifiable
  - Disadvantages: Time consuming and lacks feedback
- **Nonverbal Communication**
  - Advantages: Supports other communications and provides observable expression of emotions and feelings
  - Disadvantage: Misunderstanding body language or gestures can influence the receiver's interpretation of the message

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Nonverbal Communication

- **Body Movement**
  - Unconscious motions that provide meaning
  - Shows extent of interest in another and relative perceived status differences
- **Intonations and Voice Emphasis**
  - The way something is said can change meaning
- **Facial Expressions**
  - Show emotion
- **Physical Distance between Sender and Receiver**
  - Depends on cultural norms
  - Can express interest or status

EXHIBIT 11-2

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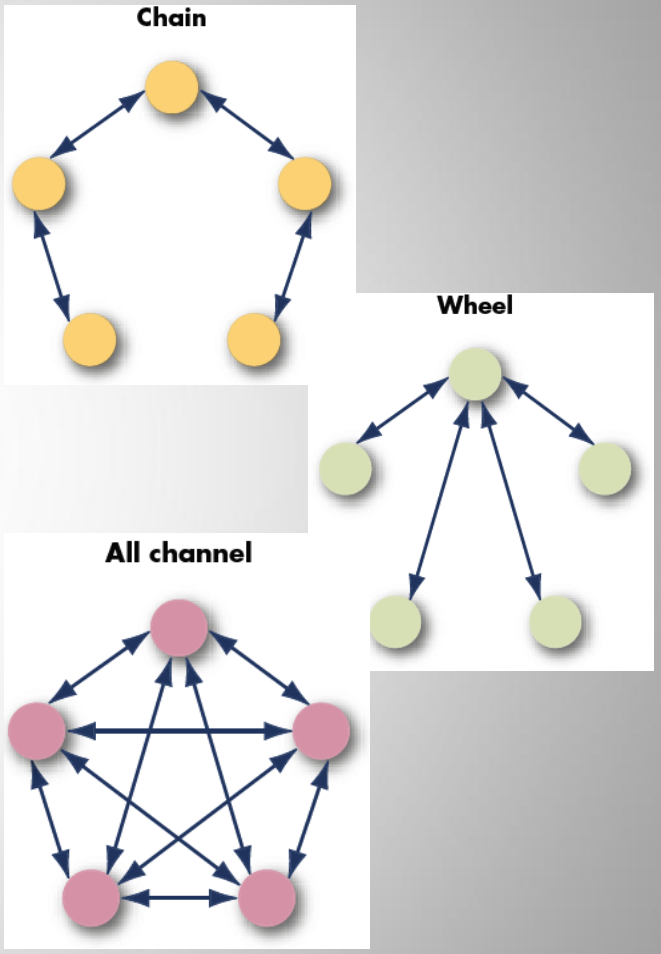
Three Common Formal Small-Group Networks

- **Chain:**
  - Rigidly follows the chain of command
- **Wheel:**
  - Relies on a central figure to act as the conduit for all communication
  - Team with a strong leader
- **All Channel:**
  - All group members communicate actively with each other
  - Self-managed teams



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Small Group Network Effectiveness

- **Small group effectiveness depends on the desired outcome variable**

	TYPES OF NETWORKS		
Criteria	**Chain**	**Wheel**	**All Channel**
Speed	**Moderate**	**Fast**	**Fast**
Accuracy	**High**	**High**	**Moderate**
Emergence of a leader	**Moderate**	**High**	**None**
Member satisfaction	**Moderate**	**Low**	**High**

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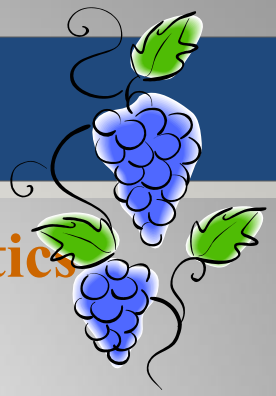
The Grapevine



- **Three Main Grapevine (Gossip) Characteristics**
  1. Informal, not controlled by management
  2. Perceived by most employees as being more believable and reliable than formal communications
  3. Largely used to serve the self-interests of those who use it
- **Results from:**
  - Desire for information about important situations
  - Ambiguous conditions
  - Conditions that cause anxiety
- **Insightful to managers**
- **Serves employee's social needs**

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Reducing Rumors

1. Announce timetables for making important decisions
2. Explain decisions and behaviors that may appear inconsistent or secretive
3. Emphasize the downside, as well as the upside, of current decisions and future plans
4. Openly discuss worst-case possibilities—they are almost never as anxiety-provoking as the unspoken fantasy

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Electronic Communications: E-mail

- **E-mail**
  - Advantages: quickly written, sent, and stored; low cost for distribution
  - Disadvantages:
    - Messages are easily and commonly misinterpreted
    - Not appropriate for sending negative messages
    - Overused and overloading readers
    - Removes inhibitions and can cause emotional responses and flaming
    - Difficult to get emotional state understood
    - Non-private: e-mail is often monitored and may be forwarded to anyone

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Electronic Communications: Instant/Text Messaging

Forms of "real time" communication of short messages that often use portable communication devices.

- Explosive growth in business use
- Fast and inexpensive means of communication
- Can be intrusive and distracting
- Easily "hacked" with weak security
- Can be seen as too informal

➢ **Instant Messaging**

- Immediate e-mail sent to receiver's desktop or device

➢ **Text Messages (SMS)**

- Short messages typically sent to cell phones or other handheld devices

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Electronic Communications: Networking Software

- **Linked systems organically spread throughout the nation and world that can be accessed by a PC**

- **Includes:**
  - Social networks like MySpace® and Facebook®
  - Professional networks like LinkedIn®
  - Corporate networks such as IBM's BluePages®

- **Key Points:**
  - These are public spaces – anyone can see what you post
  - Can be used for job application screening
  - Avoid "overstimulating" your contacts

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Electronic Communications: Blogs and Videoconferencing

- **Blogs: Web sites about a single person (or entity) that are typically updated daily**
  - A popular, but potentially dangerous activity:
    - Employees may post harmful information
    - Such comments may be cause for dismissal
    - Can be against company policy to post in a blog during company time and on company equipment/connections

- **Videoconferencing: uses live audio and video Internet streaming to create virtual meetings**
  - Now uses inexpensive webcams and laptops in place of formal videoconferencing rooms

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Choice of Communication Channel

The model of "media richness" helps explain an individual's choice of communication channel

- Channels vary in their capacity to convey information

A "rich" channel is one that can:

- Handle multiple cues simultaneously
- Facilitate rapid feedback
- Be very personal

- **Choice depends on whether the message is routine**
- **High-performing managers tend to be very media-sensitive**

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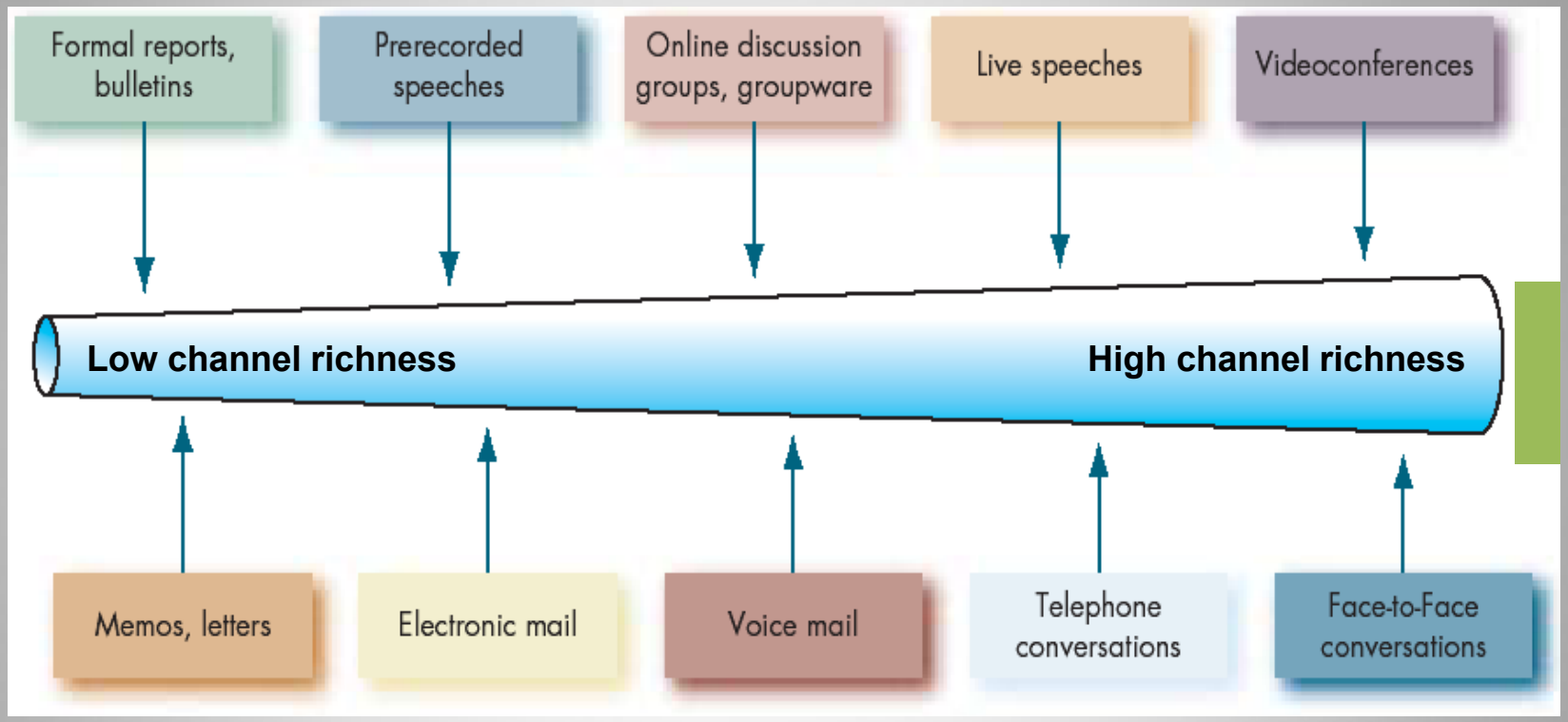
Media Richness Model



Source: **Based on R.H. Lengel and D.L. Daft, "The Selection of Communication Media as an Executive Skill," *Academy of Management Executive*, August 1988, pp. 225–32; and R.L. Daft and R.H. Lengel, "Organizational Information Requirements, Media Richness, and Structural Design," *Managerial Science*, May 1996, pp. 554–72. Reproduced from R.L. Daft and R.A. Noe, *Organizational Behavior* (Fort Worth, TX: Harcourt, 2001), p. 311.**

EXHIBIT 11-6

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Barriers to Effective Communication

- **Filtering**
  - A sender's manipulation of information so that it will be seen more favorably by the receiver
- **Selective Perception**
  - People selectively interpret what they see on the basis of their interests, background, experience, and attitudes
- **Information Overload**
  - A condition in which information inflow exceeds an individual's processing capacity
- **Emotions**
  - How a receiver feels at the time a message is received will influence how the message is interpreted
- **Language**
  - Words have different meanings to different people

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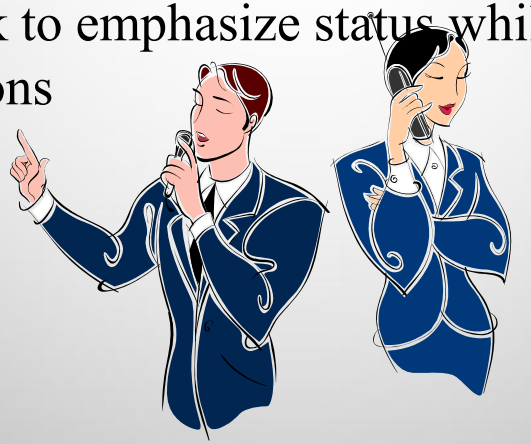
More Barriers to Effective Communication

- **Silence**
  - An absence of information due to employees' apprehension of being belittled or ignored on voicing divergent opinions or concerns
- **Communication Apprehension**
  - Undue tension and anxiety about oral communication, written communication, or both
- **Gender Differences**
  - Men tend to talk to emphasize status while women talk to create connections



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Politically Correct Communication

Communication so concerned with being inoffensive that meaning and simplicity are lost or free expression is hampered

- **Certain words do stereotype, intimidate, and insult**
  - In a highly diverse workforce this is problematic:
    - "Garbage" becomes "post-consumer waste materials"
    - "Quotas" become "educational equity"
    - "Women" become "people of gender"
  - Such non-standard sanitizing of potentially offensive words can reduce the clarity of messages

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Global Implications

- **Cross-cultural factors increase communication difficulties**
- **Cultural Barriers:**
  - Semantics: some words aren't translatable
  - Word Connotations: some words imply multiple meanings beyond their definitions
  - Tone Differences: the acceptable level of formality of language
  - Perception Differences: language affects worldview
- **Cultural Context:**
  - The importance of social context to meaning
  - Low-context cultures (like the U.S.) rely on words for meaning
  - High-context cultures (like India) gain meaning from the whole situation

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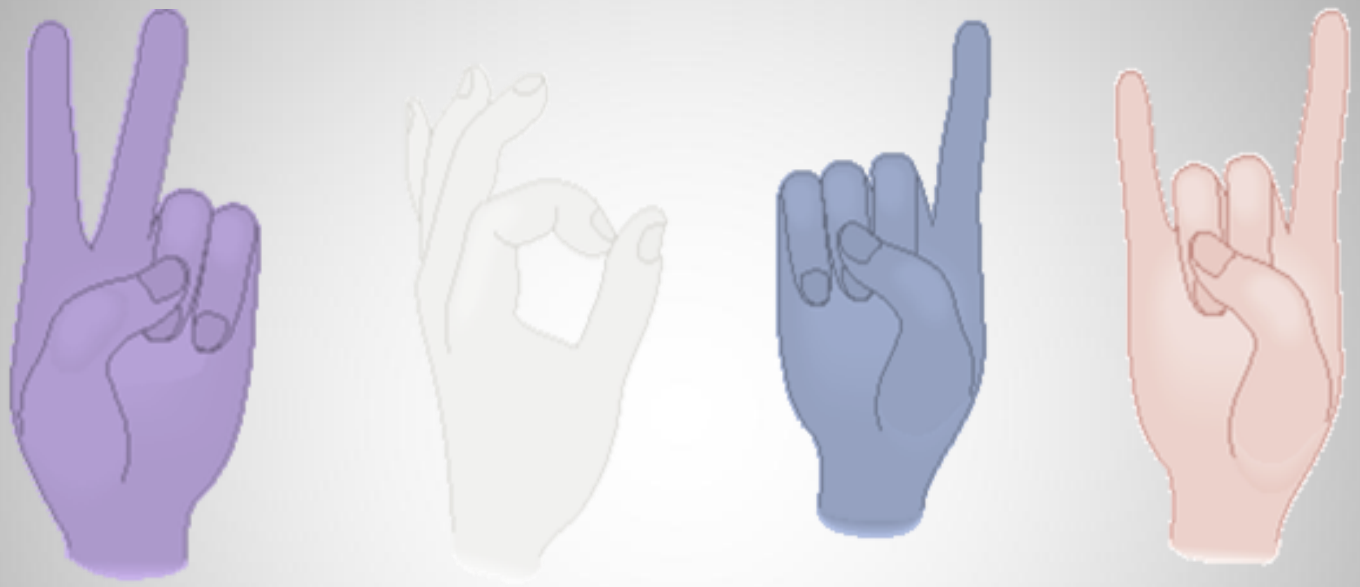
Body Language Issues



All of these common U.S. hand signs are offensive somewhere in the world.

SEE EXHIBIT 11-7

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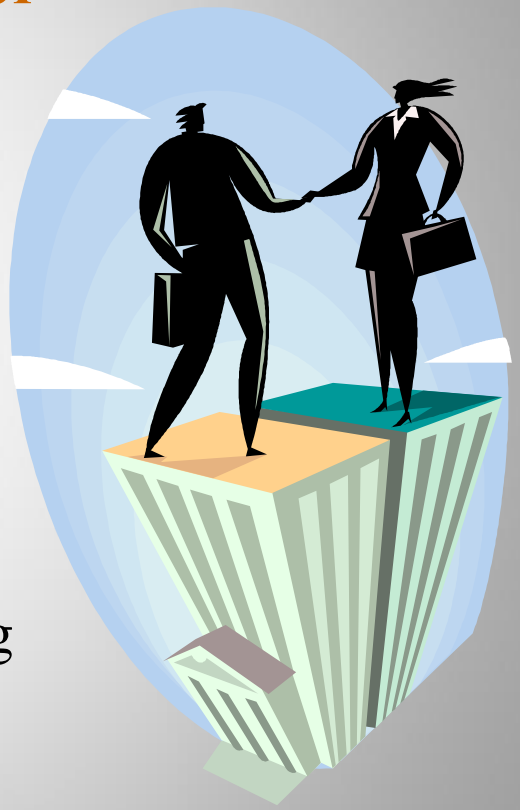
A Cultural Guide

- **To reduce your chance of making a *faux pas* in another culture, err on the side of caution by:**
  - Assuming differences until similarity is proven
  - Emphasizing description rather than interpretation or evaluation
  - Practicing empathy in communication
  - Treating your interpretations as a working hypothesis



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Questions

- What are the functions and process of communication?
- What are the communication differences between downward, upward, and lateral communication sent through small-group networks and the grapevine?
- What are the methods of oral communication, written communication, and nonverbal communication?
- What are some common barriers to effective communication?

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Summary and Managerial Implications

- **The less employees are uncertain, the greater their satisfaction; good communication reduces uncertainty!**
- **Communication is improved by:**
  - Choosing the correct channel
  - Being a good listener
  - Using feedback
- **Potential for misunderstanding in electronic communication is higher than for traditional modes**
- **There are many barriers to international communication that must be overcome**

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